Sulphur Import: How to Make It Profitable

Tonnage needed, profit by purchase price, and levers · Uzbekistan → South Korea · 30 October 2026

Bottom line. Tonnage alone does not create profit. Above ~250–500 t the cost of moving each tonne stops falling (~$200/t in containers, ~$125/t in bulk). **Profit per tonne = sale price − buy price − logistics.** Target **500–1,000 t per deal bought at ≤ $600/t** in containers, or **3,000 t+ bought at ≤ $650/t** in bulk. For 10% margin the sale price must be ≥ ~$280/t above the buy price (containers) or ≥ ~$215/t (bulk).

1. Logistics + fees per tonne (excluding the sulphur itself)

Tonnage	How it ships	Cost per tonne
25 t	1 container	$271
100 t	4 containers	$213
500 t	20 containers	$198
1,000 t	40 containers	$196
3,000 t	Rail wagons + bulk vessel	$126
10,000 t	Rail wagons + bulk vessel	$125

Container cost flattens at ~$196/t from ~1,000 t. Bulk (≥ 3,000 t) cuts it to ~$125/t.

2. Profit by tonnage and purchase price (sale price $900/t delivered)

Buy price	100 t containers	500 t containers	1,000 t containers	2,000 t containers	3,000 t bulk
$550/t	$11,101 (12%)	$63,217 (14%)	$128,364 (14%)	$258,656 (14%)	$594,561 (22%)
$600/t	$5,865 (7%)	$37,041 (8%)	$76,011 (8%)	$153,950 (9%)	$437,503 (16%)
$650/t	$630 (1%)	$10,865 (2%)	$23,658 (3%)	$49,244 (3%)	$280,444 (10%)
$680/t	−$2,511 (-3%)	−$4,841 (-1%)	−$7,754 (-1%)	−$13,579 (-1%)	$186,209 (7%)

3. Minimum targets

Shipping mode	Tonnage per deal	Max buy price	Spread needed for 10% margin
Containers	500–1,000 t	≤ $600/t	sale ≥ buy + ~$280/t
Bulk	≥ 3,000 t	≤ $650/t	sale ≥ buy + ~$215/t

4. Five levers to widen the spread

• **Buy cheaper ($50–130/t):** direct annual contract with Uzbekneftegaz / Turkmengaz instead of single exchange lots; monthly volume earns discounts; lump sulphur is usually cheaper than granular.
• **Sell to the right clients (+$50–300/t):** big users (fertilizer, sulphuric acid, zinc/metal plants) take 3,000 t+ and unlock bulk; specialty grades (powder for agriculture/rubber, high purity, 25 kg bags) pay far more per tonne.
• **Cut costs ($15–30/t):** confirm 0% WTO duty instead of 2% (≈ $17/t); client letter of credit at sight removes ≈ $12/t financing; use cheap backhaul containers Central Asia → China.
• **Repeat business:** the same lane monthly lowers fixed costs and improves forwarder and producer prices.
• **No price risk:** prices are expected to fall in 2027: only buy what a client has already bought, at a fixed price (back-to-back).

5. Optimised example: 1,000 t

Case	Cost per t	Profit	Margin
Base: buy $680, duty 2%, 30-day terms, sell $900	$908	−$7,754	-0.9%
Optimised: buy $600, duty 0%, LC at sight, sell $900	$803	$96,754	10.8%
Optimised + client pays $950/t	$803	$146,754	15.4%

6. Suggested path

Stage	What to do	Your money at risk
Now	Broker: introduce clients to suppliers for 1–3% commission (≈ $9–27k on 1,000 t)	$0
First trade	500–1,000 t in containers, back-to-back, client LC, buy ≤ $600/t	Low
Scale	Monthly 3,000 t+ bulk contract with a fertilizer or acid plant	Medium, 10–16% margin

Next step: ask your clients (1) how many tonnes per month and (2) what price they pay today. ~1,000 t/month at ≥ $950/t → real business. 10–50 t at a time → broker only.

Assumptions (estimates, not quotes): Uzbekistan route; $3,520 per 20ft (25 t) to Busan; $750/container THC + hazmat truck; $1,500 docs + $15/t bagging; $350 broker/chemical check; bulk ≈ $105/t freight + $15/t discharge; duty 2% of CIF unless stated; VAT 10% recoverable; financing 8%/yr over 30 days transit + payment terms; FX buffer 1%. Confirm with forwarder, customs broker and supplier.